

What's the matter?

Everything around you is made of matter, even the things you can't see. But everything looks and acts differently—that's because matter has different forms.

Solid, liquid, or gas

The most common states of matter are solid, liquid, and gas. Each state behaves differently because the particles in their makeup move in different ways.

Four states

There are four main states of matter.



Solids have a definite shape. Most of them are hard, such as rocks.



Liquids take on the shape of their container, and have a fixed volume.



Gases have no fixed shape. They fill any space they are in, such as a balloon.



Plasma exists at very high temperatures, like inside the Sun.

Nearly everything on the Earth is solid, liquid, or gas.

Planet Earth

The Earth has a solid core, surrounded by liquid rock, on which the solid crust floats. Liquid water covers most of the crust, and a layer of gas called the atmosphere surrounds the planet.

Clouds are made of liquid water droplets and solid ice crystals—they form from water vapor, a gas.

The green areas are land, which is made of solid rocks.

The blue areas are the oceans, which are liquid water.